

Ocher starfish prey on sea creatures such as mussels and limpets. In a famous experiment, Robert Paine took them out of their rock pools to observe the effect on the rest of the food web.

Top-down cascades

This type of cascade is clearly demonstrated when a food chain is interrupted by the removal of a top predator. The ecosystem may continue to function despite the shift in species composition; alternatively, the removal of one species may lead to the ecosystem's breakdown. In the US, a trophic cascade on the coast of southern New England is believed to be responsible for the die-off of saltmarsh habitat. Recreational anglers have